Glitched

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/51393895.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), mentions of others

Additional Tags:
Whump, Whumptober, Whumptober 2023, Angst, Heavy Angst, Drama, Hurt, Blood and Injury, Major Character Injury, Injury Recovery, Amputation, One Shot, POV Third Person, Present Tense, Comes Back Wrong, Sad Ending, Mental Health Issues, Mild Hurt/Comfort, Hurt No Comfort, Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence

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Part 4 of Whumptober 2023

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by SodaWaterparks

Summary

Once She-Ra steps back through the portal, she is about to be pissed at Catra, ready to finally cut ties with her completely, but when they all come back to reality, Catra is lying there on the floor, in a puddle of blood, unmoving. And Adora changes.

What if the glitched parts of Catra from the alternate universe in 3.5-6 didn't "load" back into regular reality? What if they both came back wrong?

Notes

I know it's November, so Whumptober is technically over, but I only found out about the separate challenge of AI-Less Whumptober on the last day! And it has a whole different prompt list! So I'm still going strong cause 'tis the season to injure your blorbos!

Even though this story fits a bunch of the prompts, this one is meant for:

Prompt #26: **Came back wrong**

Plus same day bonus prompts: **Magical exhaustion or injury** and Curse

See the end of the work for more notes

Once She-Ra steps back through the portal, she is about to be pissed at Catra, ready to finally cut ties with her completely, but when they all come back to reality, Catra is lying there on the floor, in a puddle of blood, unmoving. And Adora changes.

This immediately snaps Adora into instinctual panic mode. Despite anyone's better judgement, she bolts across the room to Catra and kneels in the blood, turning her over carefully only to discover the spots on her arm and face that had been replaced by glitchy voidspace in the other reality are now completely gone. And they're bleeding out fast.

The whole experience is enough to shock the former Force Captain into hysterics. She tries desperately to wake her up, worked up as she is, but Glimmer stops her from moving Catra too much, lest she shake all the blood out of her. Everyone else comes over and Bow checks for a pulse. She's alive and breathing, but only barely - the pulse is thready and her breaths are weak and shallow.

Glimmer grabs hold of Adora's hand, turns to Shadow Weaver, holds out her other, and demands she take them to Mystacor now. They will need to get there quickly if Catra's going to survive. Adora nods up at her, and the rest of the group link hands. Glimmer shakes her hand in impatience, urging the sorceress to take it and work with them.

Beyond Catra's injuries, the whole building rumbles and strains all around them. There is more than one reason to leave here in a hurry.

Regardless of the looming threats, it still takes Shadow Weaver a moment to step forward grasp Glimmer's hand. Glimmer, upset and in emotional turmoil, mistakes it for cruel hesitation and makes mental note of it, but for now can only glare harder.

It's hard to tell what's going on behind that mask on a good day, but when Adora glances her way when it's evident the whole

group is waiting on the mystic, Adora knows the old witch, and this is not a behavior she recognizes. She knows instantly that it isn't hesitation that has stilled the sorceress. Shadow Weaver is looking past her, to Catra, with an expression she's never seen before. She can't quite figure out what it is, all she knows is she isn't delaying on purpose - Shadow Weaver is equally shocked by this.

It uses a lot of power to get them all out of there at once and to such a faraway location. So Shadow Weaver, in a daze, explains she will need to make multiple trips to do so. Glimmer and Bow share a look and then nod at the plan.

Shadow Weaver wordlessly produces a tiny vial of something she pulls from a hidden pocket and whatever it is, it does the trick.

The first group contains Adora, Catra, Glimmer, and herself. They land on the soft grass of the floating city. After alerting the Mystacor staff of their arrival, Glimmer insists on going back with Shadow Weaver to make sure she doesn't just ditch them.

Before they leave again though, Glimmer briefly holds Adora's face in her hands, makes eye contact with her and searches those lost eyes, but doesn't let go until she makes sure she sees some kind of recognition in Adora. She lets her know she'll be back as soon as she can, and directs the incoming healers to their injured enemy, if that's what you could call this. This being Adora cradling her like it's her last seconds with a lifelong lover.

Then they're gone again in a pulse of energy.

Everything that follows is almost as much of a blur to Adora as it is to Catra.

Catra wakes up suddenly in a few days time after being healed as much as possible by the Mystacor students. She wakes up in a cold sweat, terrified and sick and confused and still hurting. And things don't look right. Or feel right. But she can't quite understand what, she's too tired, exhausted beyond reason, and

everything is too “off”. She can’t get a good grasp of the full situation.

Regardless, she starts moving around, or flailing really, and breathing harder and this wakes up Adora, who has been sleeping next to her on the same bed for the past few days.

It’s almost 1am on Mystacor at the moment, and quite honestly no one was sure *if* Catra would wake up, much less when. So this much is a miracle.

Adora is quick to let Catra know she’s there, she’s safe, things are okay, to just relax, she will explain what happened, just take it easy, stay still.

Catra being Catra, of course, does not take it easy. She remains scared and disoriented and defensive and keeps squirming. She tries to sit up and use the arm that’s not there anymore and not only fails to move the way she intended to, but also falls back and catches herself on the current bandaged stump that is there, which turns out to be a big mistake because the poor stump is still raw and tender and it aches something fierce when she puts pressure on it.

Magical healing alone hadn’t been enough to mend it, and physical sutures had been needed. And they were messy. Because Adora had done them, as best she could without shaking so violently, anyway. No one else on the sorcerer island knew how to do emergency first aid of any kind and Glimmer wasn’t back yet. So Adora did them. Really, she was just glad it had been sufficient enough to hold the girl together. Now she just had to hope the materials she used wouldn’t cause infection.

Suddenly even more confused, more adrenaline pumps into Catra’s system as she grabs for her arm. She hits air. She moves up and grips around the small remaining chunk of her upper arm with knuckles turning white.

But she doesn't scream or start crying. Her mouth is open and she's sitting up in bed and it looks like she will say something for a good while. But she says nothing.

Adora is frozen next to her in a pose that was about to stop her.

Things are silent. Catra stares down at what's left of her arm, Adora stares at her.

With her one arm, she feels up the damaged side of her face next. Adora wouldn't so much describe her touching around the bandaged empty socket as 'gentle', more like efficient and obsessive. Then they both sit in silence.

They come back to Brightmoon in a few more days. Glimmer and Bow are already back here, having been needed back in the game sooner than Catra could be safely transported, and by obstinate proxy, She-Ra.

Catra is more than a little messed up now. Physically and mentally. The trauma has confined her to a room in Brightmoon castle, not only because she's still technically an enemy to the kingdom, more or less currently a prisoner of war, but also because she's having horrible anxiety and panic attacks and when she works herself into a frenzy, she becomes a danger to everyone around her, including herself.

She's not *really* a threat though. She's not even in good enough shape to get out of bed. But Adora has begged for clemency on her behalf and the others were trying to honor it to some degree. Not in an official capacity yet, but in an empathetic one, friends feeling sorry for their close personal companion and hero of the nation. So no one says anything about it.

Not nearly enough time has passed yet that the group really know what to do with the severely injured Horde leader anyway. It's an unusual situation to say the least.

Then there is the matter of the crown suddenly shifting heads, unexpectedly, which is its own whole can of worms. Another

concurrent disaster. Adora makes an effort to apologize profusely to Glimmer in the following days, numerous times, but they never seem to go particularly well. She doesn’t expect them to anyway. Doesn't expect Glimmer to forgive her.

Glimmer supposes she will bring up what to do with Catra in a vote with the princesses in the next couple of days or weeks, though she is very acutely aware that Adora, with her big puppy dog eyes, very much wants her to grant a pardon. So the new queen hasn’t announced anything yet. Nevermind the fact that they haven’t even heard yet what Catra thinks, if she even wants asylum. Politically, everything is on hold in a tense stalemate for the time being.

Strategically, too. It seems the whole world has been put on pause, if only to regather everyone’s bearings after the portal opened and closed.

Adora doesn’t know if others experienced the portal’s effects too, saw and lived in the other reality for a time, beyond the immediate people she knows. She is too preoccupied to ask.

For the most part, Adora is glued to Catra’s bedside. Adora’s never seen anything like this, never truly seen gruesome combat casualties like this before, never seen PTSD in full swing, much less anything like this from Catra of all people. Her former-friend current-something came back from the portal damaged in more ways than one. In more ways than could be seen.

It messes Adora up too just to see it.

Despite all sorts of warnings from her friends and the guards alike, seeing Catra in this state snapped Adora right back into her old role as their dual protector. Overprotective mode. Super overprotective mode. She couldn’t leave Catra alone like this. Not like this. In fact, after this, she probably will never leave her alone again.

On top of that, Catra cries out for her. In the night, when she leaves the room. How can she just ignore her sobbing for Adora to be with her, still scared and confused in her delirium?

Catra hasn't entirely shaken the general disorientation of the situation yet, hasn't been fully lucid enough to grasp the extent of the injuries, and Adora starts to worry it's because she's becoming septic. She checks her forehead for a temperature religiously.

Better healers have arrived by now. The first responders on Mystacor had just been whoever happened to be nearby where they teleported to. The real professionals inspect Adora's initial sloppy stitchwork, but okay it in the end, at least under the conditions of applying lots of antiseptic to the wounds and prescribing a round of antibiotics, just in case. They're keeping a close eye on it. But Adora's keeping an even closer one. Maybe too close. Maybe an overly paranoid one.

Adora hasn't left Catra's room in days. She won't. There are guards outside and healers checking in and other various staff and advisors floating about the castle these days.

But Catra demands to be held at night, and must be the one closest to the wall when Adora lays with her, so She-Ra remains here.

At night, Catra will insist without words, by pulling and holding Adora's arm tightly around herself with her good arm in a vice grip until Adora reassures her enough times that she's there, she has her.

Things change when Catra starts to get a little bit better. She goes back to hating Adora. Upset about being here, about being "captured". Becomes violent and temperamental. But she's still too weak and too unused to not having an entire limb, so she's practically useless.

It breaks Adora's heart all over again when things change. Catra's a sore loser, but it seems to hurt Adora deeper.

She is watching a caged wild feral animal now, who'd rather grind her own claws down to bloody shreds rather than risk being touched.

She doesn't know how to get Catra to stop. Nothing she says or does seems to soothe her.

She swipes so feebly at guards, at restraints, at Adora. But the futility nor the sheer weakness of her actions didn't matter anymore. Buried trauma exhumed by fresh fear have created a cornered rabid fighter. Regaining and retaining any control whatsoever becomes a primal survival instinct for her.

Adora can't get near her anymore. Can't even speak to her. But she understands it, much to the surprise of the remaining duo of their Best Friend Squad. If anything, Glimmer and Bow maybe expected to still see slivers of the former Horde soldier turned goofball they'd grown so close to. That is not what they saw now.

Adora snaps too, just, differently than Catra. But she is suddenly a different person as well. Suddenly she is someone Glimmer and Bow don't recognize. She's despondent. It seemed like everything Adora had ever been fooled into believing in the Horde was now something she has fully accepted and recognizes without question. Adora can even see it in herself, in Catra, in the distinct ways they were raised and treated and groomed.

Bow and Glimmer both bristle at hearing Adora talk so candidly. It's incredibly off-putting and the apparently realized explicit details Adora tells them about their childhood are nauseating. Adora brushes it off.

She starts to answer questions about her and Catra's shared past actually very insightfully. But it's horrible. The phrasing, the emotions that fade more and more each day, the lack of spirit, the lack of shock. It is so much worse to hear it directly from their broken friend. Adora just doesn't care anymore.

It’s been a few tumultuous weeks of this game of start-and-stop with Catra. She’s slowly progressing through the stages of grief and self pity. Rage and outbursts filled with screaming over any voices that tried to soothe her slowly starts to cool into a drowning deep depression. No one can decide which is worse.

Adora sits at her door and waits. Sometimes it’s in the hall outside, sometimes she can manage to stay in the room. But she doesn’t stray far from the door now, despite no longer being physically or verbally attacked. Despite seeing Catra across the same room, curled into a corner, sobbing or moaning. She’s clearly traumatized too. But refuses to be removed from this weirdly sadistic form of self inflicted torture when Glimmer worries about her, gently asks her to take a break, go on a walk with her. Adora only worries about Catra. She’s stuck like this. She’s pretty sure even her thoughts are stuck too. The rush of the past couple weeks slams into a brick wall.

Maybe this state of stalemate is the worst part yet, Glimmer thinks, as she can only watch one of her best friends waste away, just sitting in her hallway day in and day out. It’s not angering (which Glimmer decides would be far easier to cope with - she wishes she were angry instead), it’s just… sad. It’s agony. And it’s palpable in the air around the castle right now.

Outwardly, not much appears to change for a while. But thank fuck there is one night when Catra finally starts to call out for Adora again. Glimmer and Bow think it will boost Adora’s mood again and are encouraged by hearing them interact at all. Although, it’s a new form of heartbreak when Adora doesn’t spring into action immediately. She’s cautious, and not at all the lovable idiot who would jump off a cliff just to save her friends from danger.

She does respond nonetheless, just…slower. Catra doesn’t make a big show of it when she asks Adora to come over. She asks quietly, unsure if Adora even heard her as they stare at each other in the moonlit room. She waits and Adora does eventually come closer, but her eyes are not the same as Catra remembers. They

are far darker and less trusting, her face is uncharacteristically unreadable. Adora has always been an open book. A big dumb open book. But the ways she eyes Catra now only serves to frighten her more. The situation and the two of them are all runaway-spiraling at this point. Compounding each other's problems.

Of course, that's not new for them. They've always made each other's lives hell, in playful ways or not, gladly or otherwise. But having each other used to make it bearable too. Their relationship was always a sort of double-sided coin. But now, Adora describes it better as a double-edged sword.

Things are new and foreign, as they look at each other in the night, still and quiet and unmoving, they both see different people.

Adora always understood that fighting for the Horde would change her, to an extent. Since childhood, she'd never been under any illusion this would be pretty. But who is ever really ready for change?

Looking back, she doesn't understand how she didn't see this coming. Even before their split, the discovery of She-Ra, they were never destined to have easy lives anyway. They were never promised a pleasant future, lasting friendships. Adora marvels at her own naïveté in retrospect and Glimmer hates it when she talks about herself like that.

But there's nothing anyone can do. Catra and Adora don't recognize each other anymore, and how are they supposed to come back from that? How do you relearn an old flame's face? How do you make someone familiar to you again? There are some things you can't come back from.

Catra could bounce back from her arm, her eye, surely. But whatever bridge had been temporarily rebuilt between them over their ever-widening rift was burnt again. And worse than before, Adora believed it this time.

The pieces had all been thrown into motion at breakneck speeds, and now no one is sure where things will go from here.

At this point, the best anyone could hope for is damage control.

End Notes

My least favorite (read: favorite) part of this was making Adora sad too. It has a unique sting that I hate. Thanks for reading, now we can be sad together.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!